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Coins as Agents of Cultural Definition in Islam

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Money speaks sense in a language all nations understand. Mrs. Aphra Behn, *The Rover*, 1681

Abstract In this paper I argue that the great diversity of form and content apparent in Islamic coinages of the first six or seven centuries of Islam can be reduced to a fairly orderly system of meaning. Islamic coinages share in a group of common characteristics which confer on them what is known as a family resemblance, such that two coinages, while differing greatly from each other, may still share in the common pool of features that make them somehow Islamic. Every element in the makeup of a coin, from its material through its design, fabric, script, language, textual expression, and general content, has a part to play in this and makes a statement on the overt, literal level as well as on other levels. The cumulative effect of all this is to create a numismatic metalanguage which serves to define Islamic coins as Islamic (and therefore, by extension, also to define non-Islamic coins as non-Islamic). The boundaries thus defined and erected are part of the overall cultural definition of the medieval Islamic world.

One of the most popular misconceptions about medieval Islam (one extremely productive, too, of popular misunderstanding) is that relating to the representation of human images. It is widely supposed, even among those who should know better, that such representation is forbidden, and the reason for this supposed prohibition is assumed to be the fear that such images might become objects of adoration or worship. It is true, of course, that adoration of images is forbidden, and it is true, too, that, because of their possible use as objects of worship, the production of human or other animate images is censured. But it is important to note that this is not the same thing as a prohibition. The distinction itself is less important than the fact that the

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apparent exceptions to what is thought of as a rule are simply exceptions to a general practice, not deviations from a rule. Those who were thus productive of exception were not deviating from Islam, or from mainstream Islam, or anything like it. They were simply unusual. Anyone who has ever looked at the marvelous ivory boxes produced in Islamic Spain and elsewhere for princes and others in medieval Islam, or opened an illuminated manuscript of such a work as the *Maqamat* of al-Hariri, or seen the late Umayyad wall paintings of Qusayr ʿAmra, or glanced at an Arabic manuscript of a scientific text will, furthermore, know at once that their creators were not so very unusual as all that.[1] Representation of animate objects, even or especially of human figures, was far from unknown in classical and medieval Islam. And, it should be added, what the examples just cited demonstrate very well is that while we all know, or think we know, that the situation in Islamic Iran during the premodern period was rather different, with human figures appearing frequently in Iranian miniature painting from an early date, the assertion just made about representation has a special reference to Arab Islam. It is precisely in the world of *Arab* Islam, that is to say, that we find, scattered from one geographic extreme to another and across a broad chronological span, these and other examples of human and animal representation.[2]

In itself, even posed this way, this distinction might be said to lack great significance. After all, it could be argued, neither manuscripts of belletristic stories like the maqamat, nor ivory boxes and the like are the sorts of things which might lend themselves to worship (or the sorts of things which would easily find their way into the hands of great numbers of people); and so any blurring of the edges of an evidently religious prohibition is no more than what might be expected from such a rich, sophisticated, artistically eclectic, and secure civilization as that of classical and medieval Islam. We should therefore not worry about these exceptions. There is some truth to this—although, as I shall suggest below, coins cannot be so easily dismissed, from a religious point of view, as the other objects cited. And it is also true that, for all that these objects constitute exceptions to a general practice, they are not sufficient to invalidate a generalized statement to the

1. See also the medals showing human figures which were struck occasionally by Muslim rulers (in, e.g., Bahrami 1952, especially plate 1). For scientific manuscripts with representations of human figures included purely, it seems, for decorative purposes, see Weitzmann (1952: especially 252, for the earliest datable example, an Arabic Dioscorides of A.D. 1083).

2. Among a great variety of publications on this question and related matters, cf. Lammens (1930 [1915]), Marçais (1932), Cresswell (1946, with extensive bibliography), and Karabacek (1876 [non vidi]). See also, from an extensive literature on the links with the Byzantine and Sassanian past, Grierson (1979 [1960]), Grabar (1957: 67–74), and Rosen-Ayalon (1984).

effect that the representation of human and animal images is certainly unusual in the artistic manner of classical and medieval Arab Islam.

All this is by way of preamble to my main concern here, namely, the development of the designs which we find on Islamic coins of the classical and medieval periods and the underlying rationales of that development. In fact, we have to speak of developments, in the plural, for what we find may be seen as a series of rather different, though intersecting, paths taken by the various dynasties and other coin-issuing authorities in the first five or six centuries of Islam. I shall be arguing here that, beyond the immediate and specific messages contained in the designs and textual contents of coins in this period, we are faced also with a manner of discourse, a kind of symbolic language, which made of coins, as of much else, boundary markers in the symbolic universe of Islam.

Arabs living in the peninsula before the rise of Islam had no coins of their own, and, to the extent that they used coinage at all, they made do with the coins of their neighbors.[3] The vast conquests of the generation following the death of Muhammad, which brought the Arabs out of the peninsula and made them rulers of a great state built on the ruins of the ancient world, also brought them into direct contact with the systems and forms of a monetary economy, making it necessary for them to issue coins themselves and, consequently, to concern themselves with the design and content of the coins which they issued. Here, as in many other areas, they temporized. They took their time; they took on the ways of their predecessors; gradually, they came to realize that change was possible, that it might even be desirable and necessary.

The problems represented by coinage in general go hand in hand with all those problems entailed by any new, alien rule over conquered territories: a linguistic accommodation of some sort is needed to make it possible for ruler to communicate with ruled, and vice versa; and some change in visible messages, in terms of design or symbolic language at the lowest level, is at least desirable in order to make the change, or the nature of the change, or the supposed or asserted nature of the change visible and comprehensible to different sorts of audiences, at least to the extent that this is deemed necessary and/or desirable by the new rulers.

3. Langlois (1859) considers this, showing that among the Arabs outside southern Arabia at least, only non-Arabian coins circulated, but southern Arabia is not really relevant here. The reasons why no coins were produced locally in pre–Islamic Arabia, outside the South, seem clear: on the one hand, the absence of a need for them (cf. the relative scarcity of local mintings there in later periods, too), and, more importantly still for the early period, the absence of centralized nodes of authority which might have served as coin-issuing bodies.

What form, or forms, did such changes take under early Islamic rule? How were these different messages expressed? Most importantly, what were these messages? Messages of this sort come in many different forms. One of the most obvious is simply their expression in words, their textual content. The very earliest Islamic coins appear to have been the modified coins of their predecessors, counter-marked or stamped with various designs indicating Islamic rule. Some such marks included the words *bism Allah* (in the name of God), or just *lillah* (for God). Others, on coins marked by Kharijis, consisted of Khariji slogans: *la hukma illa lillah* (judgment belongs only to God [Walker 1941]).[4] A coin stamped with a ruler's name and titles as well as the name of the mint and the date of issue (occasionally also the name of a mint official and even the denomination of the coin) provides the student of a coin with a good deal of information; for those who have to use such coins as part of their daily activities, on the other hand, this information can be of great importance, ensuring the coin's legitimation, attesting (although not always or necessarily with the same degree of reliability) to its authenticity, its quality, and so on. It is just such sets of authenticating, legitimating pieces of information that are required if money is to perform its main function of enabling the exchange of different, unequal, and incommensurable forms of wealth to proceed smoothly, freed of the inconvenience and awkwardness of the barter system.

However, such messages operate at different levels and perform functions of different sorts: beyond the more mundane types of information conveyed by the coin's text, the names and titles of a ruler, the name which he gives to the town where he mints his money, and other such words may convey other messages, including claims to authority going far beyond the reality, such as claims to spiritual as well as political authority. Likewise, the religious formulas which a ruler employs are likely to be (indeed, are almost bound to be) more than just pious expressions—they may also constitute, through their formulation, political messages. Such messages could reflect the distinction, and the hostility, between Shiite and Sunni, Fatimid and Abbasid or Umayyad (depending on geography), Umayyad and Abbasid, or Muslim and non-Muslim.[5] In the extreme west, for example, the coins of the Midrarids of Sijilmasa, which I recently had occasion to examine, can be fit into a model incorporating very similar messages expressed

4. All of these expressions and slogans are in Arabic and in Arabic script.
5. Shamma (1976) provides a compilation of such slogans (see also the Khariji slogan mentioned earlier). I have deliberately chosen not to consider here in any detail the question of the intended or actual audiences for political slogans; although related to the present subject, it is a separate and complicated issue which calls for separate, extended treatment.

in very similar ways, but serving to expound and deliver very different messages on behalf of three different and mutually opposed dynasties (See Kassis 1988; Wasserstein 1992). Similarly, the coins of the Spanish Umayyads, of their various successors in fifth/eleventh-century Iberian statelets, and of their Almoravid successors in their turn all claimed to be issued in the name of the "Commander of the Faithful"—but all three sets of coin-issuing rulers meant different things when they referred to the institution and its occupant.[6]

At yet another level, a set of codes conveys messages and passes on information. This is the system of heraldic devices which we find so notably among the Mamluks.[7] Heraldry offers a less direct system of communication than others because it uses signs, rather than words, to communicate; but again, precisely for that reason it may well be a more effective system because it does not require literacy on the part of those who have to read, as it were, the messages conveyed by its codes. These heraldic devices served to formulate and transmit messages about the issuers of the coins. However, the content of those messages was limited, amounting to little more, in effect, than the identity of the people who stamped their coins with their devices and, implicitly, with their claims to rulership. And, of course, such devices were not, despite their wordless character, necessarily any more legible or comprehensible to those who saw them: heraldry constitutes a quasi-linguistic system, but, like all linguistic systems, it has to be learned. Just as the device on a medieval European knight's shield might serve as a means of identification only if it were properly understood, so the device of a Mamluk ruler of Egypt or Syria was opaque to all except those who knew how to read it.[8] Nevertheless, it has one

6. We may wonder, too, what was intended by the petty rulers of ephemeral Islamic statelets in Spain at the time of the collapse of Almohad power who occasionally put a reference to the Abbasid caliphs, themselves on the verge of extinction, on their coinage. See Burns (1973: 30 [Ibn Hud], 33 [Zayyan Ibn Mardanish], 355) and Vives y Escudero (1893: 362, no. 2122 [Zayyan], no. 2123 [Ibn Mahfuz]; 363, no. 2129 [anon.]; 364, no. 2131; 366, nos. 2140–45; 367, no. 2146 and no. 2148; 368–69, nos. 2151–59 [all B. Hud]; these last include a few specimens which are dated, continuing as late as 656/1258). The coincidence of the date here with the fall of Baghdad and the end of the Abbasid caliphate is intriguing.

7. Cf. Mayer (1932) and the relevant sections of Balog (1964). Islamic heraldry deserves further study, especially in relation to that of Europe.

8. There is one important limitation on such heraldic devices as a communication system in Islam that relates to a difference between Islamic society and that of medieval Christian Europe. In Europe, such devices as coats of arms served, among other things, to indicate identity in terms of descent, background, and dynastic and marriage links. In Mamluk Egypt and Syria, by contrast, heraldic devices could only identify a single individual or, at most, his house. The dynamic use of the heraldic device, as it developed in Christian Europe, was precluded by the different statuses of both women and Mamluks (as well as the descendants of

important feature in common with the purely linguistic messages of the great majority of Islamic coins. Not only can it be read by those who do know how to read, but it also serves as a message sent deliberately and consciously by the ruler who uses it. This is not the case with all of the sorts of codes that concern me here.[9]

None of this, I think, should surprise anyone: we are, or should be, all acquainted not just with the changeover from Greek and Persian to Arabic in the administration of the state under ʿAbd al-Malik, but also with the accompanying changeover from coinage rather similar in style to that of the pre-Islamic period to coinage with a more Islamic style. My point here is that this changeover was not simply a changeover for that period alone; it served notice on Muslim and non-Muslim alike of permanent changes, of changes in what we may term the metalanguage of Islam, of changes, that is to say, in the way that Islam, as distinct from the cultures of Byzantium and Persia, saw itself and articulated itself. These were messages which served to draw lines of demarcation; they laid down boundaries and marked differences, and they continued to do so, in strikingly varied ways, for centuries thereafter.

Of course, it is clear that everything stamped on a coin carries with it some meaning, has some significance. As the examples cited here show, the forms and contents of the coinages of Islam carried messages on more than one level. There is a sense, as I have suggested, in which we can look at coins as conveying these messages in a sort of metalanguage, one possessed of its own lexicon. To the extent that we may do so, it seems to me, further, that we can consider the coins of Islam and, mutatis mutandis, the coins of different parts of Islam (or, for that matter, of other areas and cultures) as marking off boundaries, or territories, not so much geographical (as will be seen in a moment) as psychological. Clearly, we can speak of "Islamic coins," but it is not so easy to say quite what we mean by that. I referred above to styles that were more pre-Islamic as distinct from styles that were more Islamic. But what does such a distinction mean for this early period? Or, more simply, in the present context, how do we recognize an Islamic coin as Islamic? And how might we say that Islamic coins differ from non-Islamic coins? On the surface and at first glance, these look like simple questions and like questions of little significance. I hope to show that they are certainly not simple and, possibly, to suggest that they have

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Mamluks) in the Islamic societies of the Middle East. This, of course, is also one of the factors which help to account for the relatively undeveloped nature of heraldry itself in Islam.

9. For a sensitive analysis of a case which seems to straddle the boundaries between two sets of codes, namely, symbols and words, see R. W. Bulliet (1974).

a certain significance for our understanding of cultural definition in Islam during the Middle Ages.

The first point to consider is that two centuries after the Prophet, during the reigns of al-Amin and al-Maʾmun, fully a century and more after the reforms of ʿAbd al-Malik, with all their implications, coins aplenty still circulated in the East on which there was hardly any reference to Islam and scarcely any evidence at all of Islamic rule, coins on which, moreover, the representation of human and nonhuman features abounded.[10] Such evidence as the coins provide of having been minted by an explicitly Islamic regime is minimal. These coins are little more than slight adaptations of the coins issued by the Sassanians and others in the East before Islam. Two centuries after the arrival of Islamic rule, and a century after the reforms of ʿAbd al-Malik, the presence of such coins as these arouses some important and disturbing questions. What of prohibitions on human representation? What of Islamic rule? How are we to explain the survival of traditional forms? How are we to interpret their meanings, both for the rulers who minted them and for their subjects, who used them? In a context where we are often told that the typical Islamic coin has nothing but words on it, it is perhaps useful to be reminded that, in fact, it depends; the word "typical" begs a number of questions: typical of what? of when? of where? even, of whom?

Of course, as I have noted, these coins are mainly eastern ones; they do not really belong to the world of what became Arab Islam, but rather to the Iranian world. However, if we turn to the Arab world, or to what became the Arab world, we discover that the picture is not so very strikingly different: here, too, we find a significant degree of carryover from the past. It does not last quite so long, perhaps, and the degree of obvious difference from earlier models increases quite rapidly; but, by the same token, the degree of interpenetration of symbol and of implied message remains very high (see Walker 1956). Possibly because of this, it might be argued, what we are witnessing is an earlier and fuller changeover to new models here than in the East. The challenge posed to Islam here, by Christianity and by forces outside the Islamic empire, in Byzantium, was stronger and more dangerous and hence called for a firmer response than in the East.

In an important article published some forty years ago, the late George Miles (1952) drew attention to a remarkable coin type which, he argued, represented the survival of one of a series of experiments

10. See Walker (1941). This work contains forty excellent plates of many of the coins included in Walker's catalogue: almost all of these coins, as can be seen from a glance at the plates, portray a human head; almost none of them has more than a couple of words in Arabic.

in early Islamic numismatic iconography. These experiments, Miles suggested, were based largely on adaptations of preexisting types among the coinages of the Muslims' predecessors in the Middle East. He even went so far as to argue that the figure shown on his coin type represented not an anonymous, idealized royal type, as such figures did on pre-Islamic Sassanian coins and on early Islamic types based on these, but rather a royal portrait, probably, he suggested, of ʿAbd al-Malik himself. Such a portrait would not, of course, have been an authentic likeness, but an idealized portrait of the caliph. Whatever one makes of this last suggestion, Miles seems to have been absolutely right in his basic proposal that these coins represent early attempts to devise a numismatic iconography for Islam at a time before portraiture had become disallowed. His last paragraph is of considerable interest in the present context:

> What a misfortune really, from our point of view, that ʿAbd al-Malik was not persuaded to adopt this design, or something like it, as the model for his reform! Chance or bigotry rejected the experiment. In place of the endless series of monotonous purely epigraphic coins which persisted almost without interruption in all parts of the Islamic world down to recent times, we might have had a treasure-house of constantly varying iconography reflecting the regional development of Muslim ritual art throughout the centuries. (Ibid.: 171)

I shall return to the single major exception to this general rule below.

The lexicon of Islam's numismatic metalanguage has several different layers of signification. There is, as has been seen, one layer comprising simple types of information—denomination, date, mint name, issuing official, and ruler. There is another layer consisting of information-by-implication: political claims, religious/political slogans, and the like—all of which, like the information of the previous layer, is deliberately communicated by the ruler who issues a coin. In this layer, too, although with a qualification, we may place the heraldic devices stamped on Mamluk coinages. Finally, there is still another level, one at which the very forms of these explicit and sometimes not so explicit messages function as messages in their own right. In this category we find messages whose purport need not be, or need not be so clearly, understood or even intended by the senders. These messages are transmitted by a large variety of features of a coin.

The language used on a coin perhaps most obviously says something about the attitudes and policies of the issuing authority. The changeover from the use of Greek or Persian to that of Arabic as part of the reforms instituted by ʿAbd al-Malik, whatever else it meant, signaled one thing very firmly and directly: a conscious intention on the part of Arab Muslim rulers to make Arabic the language of their empire. These rulers did not intend to become assimilated (not, at

any rate, linguistically) by their subjects. The use of Arabic on these coins and on most Islamic coinage of (what subsequently became) Arab Islam made a statement about the nature of the Islamic and the Arab *oikoumene*, and, up to a point, it also sent a particular message quite self-consciously. It set up, or helped to create, one of the fundamental boundaries of the Islamic world by linguistically defining the bulk of the early western conquests as Arabic. However, this was not, whatever one might think, an obvious or a necessary step for the Muslims to have taken. There are plenty of historical examples of states whose coinage has been inscribed with a language other than that of their rulers or that used in daily life by their inhabitants. One need only think of British coinage today, where we can find inscriptions in Latin, Welsh, and Norman French as well as in English. Similarly, in Israel we can find inscriptions both in Arabic, which is not the language of the ruling group, and in English, which is not the language of any group in the population. In both cases, of course, these are historically determined situations, but so was that of first/seventh-century Syria. And, as will be seen below, a different choice could have been made.

A second element related to language is, of course, script: it may seem obvious that, where the language is Arabic, so will be the script in which that Arabic is expressed. It is not obvious at all. Indeed, if we assume that the inscriptions placed on the early post-reform coins were meant to be read by the people who would have to use the coins, then we must also assume that those people were well versed not only in the Arabic language, but also in how to write it. The population of the formerly Greek provinces of the empire was not likely, however, to know much Arabic at all by the latter part of the first/seventh century, and what they did know of it would almost certainly have been of a spoken variety. If they read Arabic at all, what they could read was written, in the vast majority of cases, in Greek script. Arabic texts, like texts in other languages, can easily be written, for most purposes, in non-Arabic scripts. The best demonstration of this is to be found in the numismatic practice of the Danishmendids and other dynasties who actually, in the fifth/eleventh century and even later, inscribed their coins with Arabic words rendered in Greek letters. Why they did so is an interesting question: quite clearly, it served some purpose to use Greek rather than Arabic script.[11] Messages written in a particular

11. See the discussion, and the material, in Vryonis (1971: 473–75, with references, and esp. 470, for an account of a surviving lead seal of Dhu al-Qarnayn, a Danishmendid prince of Melitene [1152–1161], which shows on the obverse a nimbate bust of St. Basil, the patron saint of Caesaria, over which the Danishmendids ruled, with a Greek inscription in Greek script, saying "Saint Basil," and, on the reverse, an Arabic inscription in Arabic script, saying "al-Wathiq bil-Rahim Dhu al-Qarnayn"). See also Casanova (1896 [1894–96]) and further references in the text to parallel material.

script are clearly intended for a particular audience. This is not quite so simple as it may appear: as will be seen, it is also entirely possible that messages expressed in a particular script may be intended, by virtue of that fact, not to be read, but rather to serve, qua objects, as statements about a ruler's intentions or attitude toward those subjects associated with a different language or script. What is significant is that in the first/seventh century some thought was clearly given to the choice of script for coins carrying messages in Arabic; it is possible that the choice was obvious to those who made it—although the material in this area, as in others, suggests that it was less immediately obvious than moderns might think. Once made, however, such a choice might appear to be settled for good. But the evidence of the Danishmendid coinage shows that the question had still not been finally settled even as late as the fifth/eleventh century, even in an area so central, and Islamic for so long, as this one. Here, too, the question needed to be considered anew and on rather different bases from those of four centuries earlier.

Other issues related to the choice of script can also be problematic. Even if a decision has been made to use Arabic, there are further questions, such as whether the coin will bear the diacritical marks which distinguish Arabic letters from each other. Their absence from most coins, and the consequently increased difficulty involved in reading the inscriptions, suggests that these inscriptions may not really have been intended to be read by many people at all. Another question of a similar type is whether to use the Kufic Arabic script normally employed on coins or some other one, say, the Naskhi, and even if a decision is made to remain faithful to traditional norms, further choices must still be made by those who cut the dies for the coins, or by those who instruct them to do so, over whether the forms of the letters used will be wooden and archaizing in style, for example, or flowing and elegant. The coins of the Midrarids, mentioned earlier, are generally characterized by the woodenness of the Kufic script employed on them; indeed, it may even be the case that this occasionally enables us to identify a coin as Midrarid. But the use of a wooden style must have been a deliberate choice since everything that we know about Sijilmasa and the fourth/tenth century suggests that there were plenty of available models from which the ruler and his die cutters could choose a script style. What audience is addressed here? What message is implied by such a choice? This is far from being a simple matter of decoration, particularly in the case of a minor ruler who, not quite at the mercy of more powerful neighbors, wishes to make exalted caliphal claims for himself.[12] A wooden, archaizing style may

12. For illustrations of Midrarid coins, see, for example, Lavoix (1896: plate 9, nos. 929–30); Kazan (1983: 267, illustrations of nos. 296–302); Nützel (1902: Taf.

have something to contribute to the particular claims to orthodoxy of the ruler who employs it.[13]

Beyond these elements, there are others which can also vary greatly, such as the shape of a coin. Historically, most coins have been round, that is, more or less circular in intention if not in execution. But while this may be the most obvious shape for a coin to have, it is far from being the only possible one. Square coins are well known in Islam; square dirhams, for example, were struck by the Almohads and their successors in the West, in Spain, and in North Africa (see Hazard 1952, including plates, for examples). And, in relation to another such element, coin design, we also frequently find a square within a circle on round coins from the same dynasties, again in the West, but in this case on gold coins, or dinars (ibid.). This is not simply a design element, but, as with other elements of coinage, the shape of (or on) a coin has a message to convey, a boundary to mark, in this case one related to the desire of the issuing authorities to stress their independence from predecessors in their own area and contemporaries in other areas by marking their coins (and thus also their identities) as different from those of others.

Apart from these aspects, such factors as size and weight, fabric, composition and thickness, even formal designation all clearly transmit messages, signaling differences and dividing lines, sometimes related to the intentions of the issuing authorities, sometimes to the resources available for the manufacture of their money. Significant divergences from past practices in a territory, in the weight of gold coins, for example, or in their designation, may reflect ideological or religious changes on the part of a government. The twelfth-century monetary reforms of the Almohads in North Africa and Spain are good examples of this (see Prieto y Vives 1915). The materials of which coins are composed, too, may tell the modern student a great

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5, illustration of no. 853); Wasserstein (1992 [illustrations of coins in the Israel Museum, Jerusalem, in the collection of the late Paul Balog]); and Bank Leu (1991: lot 527, illustrated on plate 25).

13. A further example of a process related to this, at one remove, is provided by the second-century A.D. Jewish leader of a rebellion against Roman rule, Bar Kokhba. He struck coins with Hebrew legends in a Jewish script; this was the script, however, of the ancient Hebrew alphabet (Heb. *raʿas* or *daʿas*), which had not been used for hundreds of years before his own time and was certainly incomprehensible to the vast majority of those for whom these coins were struck. Coins with inscriptions in the same type of script had also been struck in the second century B.C. by Hasmonean rulers; in their case, the script may have been not so much archaizing as an example of the survival of an archaic script in a comparatively small, closed circle. (It is interesting, in this context, that the same archaic or archaizing script is found in some of the manuscripts from the Dead Sea area; and the same type of script is used to this day in the Scrolls of the Law written for and by Samaritans.) See Meshorer (1982), for illustrations of the coins.

deal about the economic strengths and resources of those who issued the coins and gave vital information to those whose purchasing power depended on the value of the coins' contents.[14] Adulterating gold with silver, or silver with baser metals, would send a message, to those who could apprehend it, about the economic strength of a state or the resources of a ruler. Too abundant issues of, or overreliance on, lower denominations in such materials as copper or bronze, or even (very rarely) in lead (not to mention glass[15]), could send messages of a similar type. And the overall quality of the execution, especially of issues in materials other than gold and silver, might also have had a particular significance.

All these aspects of a coin, or of a coin type, may be the bearers of messages, and these messages may in their turn serve, as they often do, to indicate boundaries, to lay down territorial markers. In the case of the Almohads' square silver coins or their square-in-a-circle gold coins, the territory thus marked out is that of Islam, with the particular revivalist flavor imparted by the ideology of their movement. In the case of the Fatimids, who introduced a new arrangement, based on circular legends with no field, for the inscriptions on their dinars, the territory thus marked out was also in a sense geographic, for the areas where their coins typically circulated were thereby distinguished from those of the Abbasids, who remained loyal to their own, more old-fashioned layouts of legends on their coins. Language and script as well as shape and size, weight and material, and so forth all convey specific types of messages or, in more modern parlance, bits of information.

One significant feature, to which I have already referred, calls for more elaboration here, namely, the design aspect of coins that specifically concerns the appearance, or the absence, of images on the coins. I have referred already to the pre-reform coinages of both the eastern and the western provinces of the empire,[16] but these early coinages were not all that the first few centuries of Islam produced by way of coins with representations of human (and other) figures on them. It is necessary to pause here for a moment to consider the strange, often rather beautiful coins minted by several fairly small dynasties during

14. The obvious modern equivalent here is cowrie shells.

15. The question whether small glass objects with Arabic inscriptions served as weights or on occasion also as low-denomination money does not yet seem to have been settled. For the questions under study here, it is not particularly important to know whether or not they were used as money, but it is clear that if they were, they would easily fit into the schema proposed here.

16. In addition to the important article by Miles (1952) cited earlier in the text, see also Miles (1959 [a review of Walker's two-volume catalogue of the British Museum collection]); Miles (1957: nos. 7, 8); Walker (1952); and Morony (1984: 38–51).

the fifth/eleventh century and later roughly in the area of southeastern Anatolia and northern Syria and Mesopotamia. This was territory that had been largely Islamic-ruled and Muslim-inhabited for centuries. On the coinages of the Danishmendids, the Zengids, and the Artuqids, suddenly and surprisingly, human figures based on much older prototypes began to appear frequently. We find representations not only of individual humans and human types, but also of Christ enthroned and of the Virgin crowning the emperor. This seems both to fly in the face of current Islamic orthodoxy, and orthopraxy, regarding human representation and to depart very radically from the general norms of Islamic numismatic practice.[17] These coins, in other words, seem to carry messages very different from those that we might expect to find on the coins of Islamic dynasties. As we have already seen, there is another aspect in which these coins appear to depart from Islamic numismatic (and indeed other) norms, namely, the occasional use of Greek script on them. Both of these deviations seem to place such coins outside the limits of what we might define as Islamic. This is especially true of the presence of human figures on these coins. However we may define the term "Islamic" in this context, the presence by the fifth/eleventh century of human figures on a coin would certainly seem to lie outside the limits of any definition. Nevertheless, here we have human figures, while the contemporaneous issues of other Islamic dynasties exhibit the rigidly austere, purely verbal designs which are so characteristic of Islamic coinage generally.

How might we explain two such radically different, even, in their specific contexts, diametrically opposed modes of expression? There are, I think, at least two types of explanations available. The first, a static explanation, views the supposed prohibition on human representation, whatever its origins and however it is expressed in the sources (with whatever authority, etc.), as actually referring, and as generally intended and/or normally understood to refer, to the dangers of a shift from one use to another, a crossing or gliding over from an identifying, legitimating mark, or sign, to an object of worship or adoration. Proponents of this view hold that since the aim of such representation on coins is completely clear, defined as it is by the context, there is no such danger; therefore, the supposed prohibition does not apply to coins.

This explanation, as far as it goes, seems satisfactory. But it does not go very far: it is an essentially static explanation of a dynamic reality, and it is also at base a negative formulation of a positive position.

17. Cf. *Encyclopaedia of Islam*, 2d ed., s.v. "Artukids" (by C. Cahen), and s.v. "Danishmendids" (by I. Mélikoff). See also Ghalib Edhem (1894) and Lane-Poole (1875). For similar material, see Balog (1980: 48).

A more sophisticated, or at least a more complex, explanation seems called for, one which might positively account for the dynamics of the cultural and political realities of the areas and periods in question. Such an account is not, in fact, so very hard to find. The problem boils down to the need to formulate an explanation for the different modes of numismatic expression which we find in the first few centuries of Islam, an explanation which takes into account the changing political and cultural circumstances under which the rulers issued coins.

Helen Brown (1974) pointed out in a brief discussion of these coins some years ago that human figures are to be found only on the copper issues, never on the gold or silver. It had been suggested that the coins bearing images which were strange in an Islamic context might have been minted for use in trading with neighboring Christian states. But such trade would have required gold and silver coinage rather than copper, which was more suitable for small-scale, local trade. Brown went on to suggest, very tentatively, the possibility that "the change to a figured coinage was an innovation for its own sake, a reflection of the abundance of historical traces that were, and are, a commonplace of the area, and that it expressed the interest, that could not fail to engage any but the most barbarous, in the civilizations of the past, and expressed also an appreciation of what was fine and rare" (ibid.: 356). She also drew attention to the fact that some of these issues were modeled on classical or other pre-Islamic coins, specimens of which have always been extremely rare. More recently, the late Nicholas Lowick (1990b [1985]; see also 1990a [1974]) discussed these coins once again. Like Helen Brown, he drew a distinction between the gold and silver, on one hand, and the copper, on the other. He preferred to see the figure-type coins as "a species of bronze artefact rather than as humbler counterparts of the gold dinar and the silver dirham"; this categorization then permitted him to suggest that "their curious character becomes more explicable" if these coins can be seen as examples of a composite style, drawing on many sources. Copper coins in Islam, Lowick argued, have always been less affected than gold or silver ones by conventional taboos of a religious nature, and the profession of faith is generally absent from these coins. "If the dinars and scarce silver dirhams are the political manifestoes of rulers who took pride in their status as *ghazi*'s on behalf of orthodox Islam, the coppers are perhaps first and foremost secular objects, destined for everyday use in the market and tax office, and exchanged amongst persons of different races and religious persuasions" (Lowick 1990b [1985]: 160).

The story which provides the etiology for the stylistic changeover in Islamic coinage at the end of the first/seventh century has the Byzantine emperor Justinian II (r. 685–95) refusing to accept some tribute

sent to him from the caliph because it was not in coin of the normal Byzantine types and the emperor did not recognize anyone else's right to depart from those types. Were these new types bare of images? It is possible, but it seems unlikely, as the study by Miles (1952) suggests (see also Grabar 1957: 67–74). As a reaction, whether direct or indirect, to this episode (assuming that the story is true), the final abandonment of images altogether at this time is entirely plausible, especially given the context of iconoclastic controversy in the Byzantine world. Whether or not the story is true is less important than two other aspects: first, that it could be thought to be true; and second, that it is found in Byzantine, Greek, Christian sources, rather than in Syrian, Arab, Muslim ones. This second point is particularly worthy of attention as evidence of a defining act, a boundary marker, that was noticed and recognized by those outside the boundary.

There are other sorts of problems which can arise in such contexts. Dhimmis (i.e., Jews and Christians) are not ordinarily allowed, under Islamic law, to own copies of the Koran lest they treat the holy book of Islam in a disrespectful manner. Coins minted by most Islamic rulers in the classical period were usually inscribed with quotations from the Koran as well as names and epithets for God or names and titles of rulers and others which themselves included names for God. Such items as coins frequently suffer far worse fates than merely disrespectful treatment at the hands of non-Muslims. The fact that there does not seem to be any recognition of this as a problem is consistent with the talmudic judgment that coins do not defile (from a ritual point of view)—as long as they are coins. However, once they cease to be coins, by being made into jewelry, for example, their new character enables them to defile.[18] Here, the first element in the judgment, that coins do not of themselves, qua coins, carry defilement, reflects the pragmatic realization that to view coins otherwise would make life unlivable; we may assume that similar views obviated similar problems in Islam. But this is not the end of the matter, for, as I suggested earlier, coins are not quite like ivory boxes or illustrated manuscripts of the *Maqamat*. They are more likely, for one thing, to come into the hands of ordinary people, and they are also very likely to be subjected to rougher treatment than luxury items. It is precisely on account of the first consideration—that coins circulate among all classes of society—that my earlier question is of significance. If such objects bear human representations, should we not expect to find evidence of some awareness that they might encourage tendencies toward adoration? And if so, then we should be justified in also expecting to find evidence of some

18. See Meshorer (1967), resumed subsequently in Meshorer (1982: 163–65 ["The Phenomenon of the Perforated Denarii"]).

opposition to them on these grounds. The message conveyed by the contents of such coins, like the message of earlier Roman or Byzantine coins, is one of authority; again, as on those earlier coins, that message of authority has both secular and religious aspects, and it signifies the intermingling of the two which had been encouraged by rulers at all times both before and since the rise of Christianity. The danger of deification of an Islamic ruler, by one means or another, might have been no more remote than it was for those earlier societies. The example of the Fatimid al-Hakim immediately comes to mind. Coins exist, in Islam as in other societies, at a sort of remove from the rest of reality; they need to.

On the basis of the characterization presented here, that is to say, of the vocabulary and syntax of this metalanguage, it should be possible to identify a coin as Islamic if it has these characteristics, or at least a good number of them. This is not to say, of course, that a coin with Arabic writing on it is, and one with, say, Greek on it is not, by virtue of this characterization an Islamic coin: such a statement would be far too simplistic. Modern Israeli coins, for example, bear inscriptions in Arabic, but they are not Islamic; however, the coins inscribed in Greek to which I referred above are, despite their apparently non-Islamic script, nevertheless Islamic. What Islamic coins have in common is, in fact, what is known as a "family resemblance," that is, their characteristics are all taken from a common pool. This pool of characteristics constitutes the shared essence of Islamic coins, of which all reflect something; but no two types of Islamic coins will necessarily have identical characteristics.

In this sense, at least, it may be possible to identify an Islamic coin as Islamic when we see it. Does this mean, however, to pose the question implied by the title of this paper, that these coins, qua Islamic coins, somehow help to define the culture, to lay down the boundaries, of the world of Islam? I suggest that they do. And they do so in both a geographical sense and a deeper, psychological one. The very recognition of a coin as Islamic, in the sense just mentioned, implies the recognition of the boundaries dividing Muslim from non-Muslim, Islamic from non-Islamic as well. Such a coin refers unmistakably to Islamic, as distinct from non-Islamic, territory, in every sense of that word; and it does so, moreover, by means of signs and codes which are comprehensible, at different levels, to those who see and use the coins in both Islamic and non-Islamic contexts.[19] Here, an inability to read

19. It is worth stressing here that these boundaries were not only permeable, but were easily crossed by these coins and by the (or some) notions of their identity as Islamic. We have something like a quarter of a million specimens of Samanid silver in modern collections, largely from hoards in Scandinavia and the former Soviet Union. Recent research suggests that to some degree these coins were actually made for export rather than for internal Islamic use. If this is the case, these

need not imply an inability to recognize a script on a coin as Arabic, as opposed to Greek or Latin or Pahlavi, just as the presence or absence of Christian symbols can be recognized without a deep knowledge of the differences separating Christianity from Islam. Within Islam itself, similarly, the differences between one type of coinage and another may have been, although on a higher and more sophisticated level, hence one more difficult of access, just as visible. Even without a degree of literacy sufficient to read, say, the legends on a Fatimid coin and to distinguish its claims from those impressed on the coins of their Abbasid rivals, or without a clear understanding of the theological and political claims of these two dynasties, most of their coins could be easily distinguished from each other thanks to the strikingly different layouts of the two dynasties' major issues in gold. If we consider other dynasties, such as the Umayyads of Spain, in this respect, we can explain the strong resemblances between their gold issues and those of the Abbasids in terms of the Spanish rulers' well-known tendency to imitate their oriental supplanters, that desire to be more Catholic than the Abbasids which informed so much of their cultural and political purpose through many generations. In a sense, it may be argued that what we have here is less an attempt to define differences, to lay down territorial boundaries, than to eliminate such differences, to tear down certain fences. Much the same is true of other dynasties, such as the Almohads and their successors, who introduced and then maintained for generations a new shape, the square, on their gold coinage and even made silver coins in the shape of a square. Clearly, an informed understanding enables one to understand more, and perhaps better. But a complete understanding would not only be beyond the likely ability of most users of a coinage, it would also be generally quite unnecessary, even uncalled for. A limited understanding is quite sufficient—beyond that, the further understanding available to those of greater sophistication offers an audience for particular claims (political, religious, economic, etc.) made by the issuer of a coin. It is perhaps questionable whether such understanding increases awareness of dividing lines. This is symbolic affirmation on a very grand scale.

The symbolic affirmation described by Richard Ettinghausen (1974) in his well-known article on Arabic inscriptions referred to texts that were not only incomprehensible, but often so elevated as to be effec-

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coins are comparable to the Maria Theresa thaler or the British sovereign, which circulated as accepted forms of metallic wealth over large areas of the Middle East long after they had ceased to signify or function as money in their lands of origin. Such a situation would, of course, strengthen the case for viewing the designs of these coins as sets of encoded messages, which would differ considerably according to the audience.

tively invisible and hence illegible.[20] Islamic coins, on the other hand, were part of everyday life; their use, indicating that they were not rejected by their users and implying at least some degree of acceptance of the claims made on them and for them, might thereby have indirectly offered those who issued them a certain degree of comforting legitimacy.

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20. For extensions of this theme, see Nelson (1985) and Samić (1990: esp. 203).

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